

Inquiries in Sociology

Session 2 - Start a Literature Review and Think of a Research Question

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How to: Start a Literature Review and Think of a Research Question - Summary

The Literature Review in Sociology

- An academic exercise
- What, how and when to read?

The Research Question and Problematization Process

- Discussion from the text (Gustafsson et Hagström, 2018)
- Problematization in sociology: conditions for a valid scientific research question

In-Class Activity: Design Your Lit. Review Objectives and Start Reading

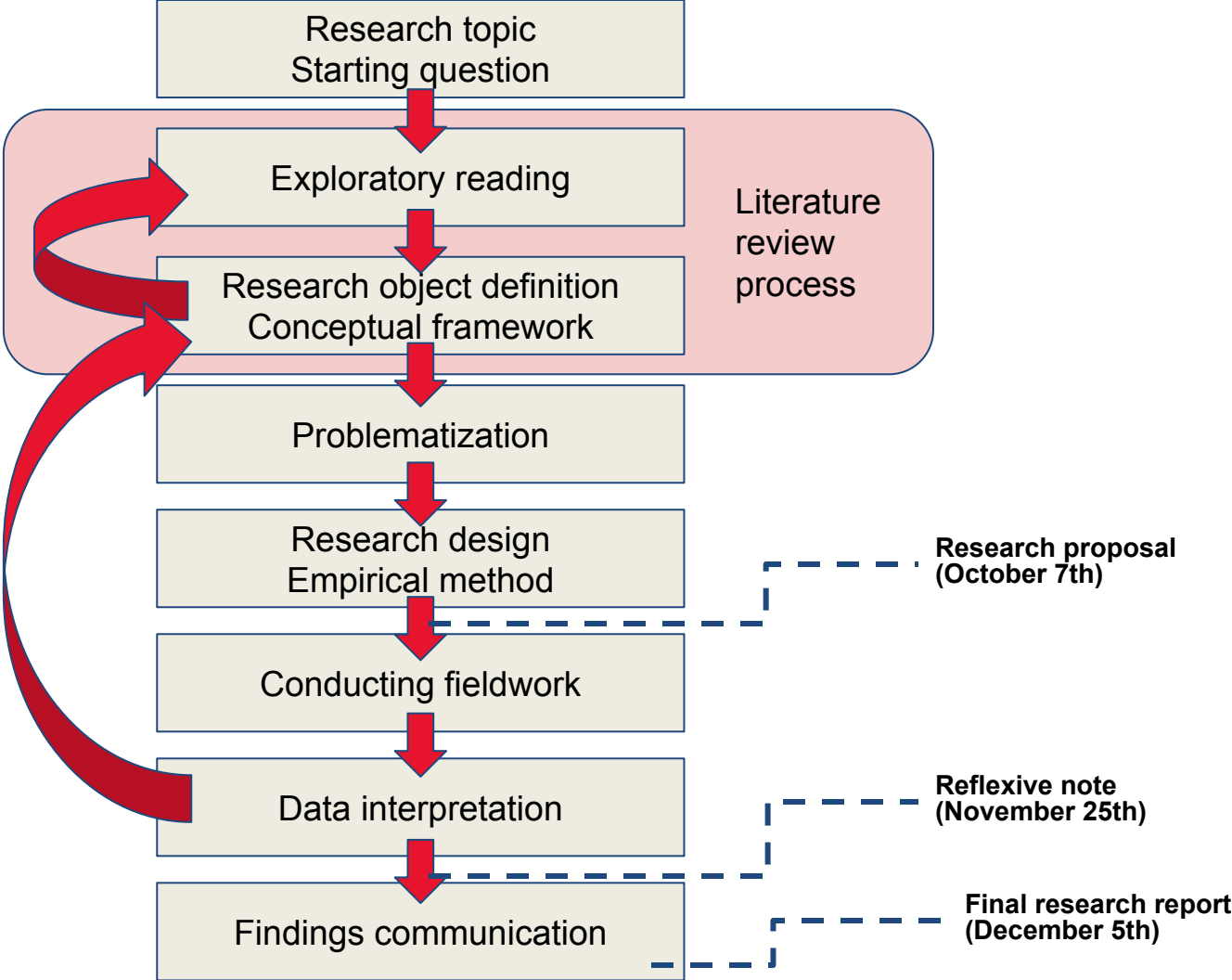
- Tips on planning your lit. review and reading *effectively*
- Groups supervision on planning your lit. review

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The Literature Review in Sociology

General Ideas

Research
Project Outline



The Literature Review in Sociology

An academic exercise:

- Literature review “serve the purpose of generally describing the extant research including methods, populations, and findings.” (Rozas et Klein, 2010, p. 389)
- **It is NOT a descriptive catalog:** it provides a more “comprehensive intellectual grounding by highlighting connections that went beyond what was known in any individual study to produce a more fully developed understanding of an issue and its larger context.” (Rozas et Klein, 2010, p. 389)

“In order to create a deeper and clearer sense of the whole and to contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of some aspect of human behavior in a complex social environment, we weave together a fabric of many small studies, of many close approximations. [...] **All knowledge is tentative; the accumulation of good research serves the purpose of aiming the search for new and improved knowledge in the most fruitful directions.**”

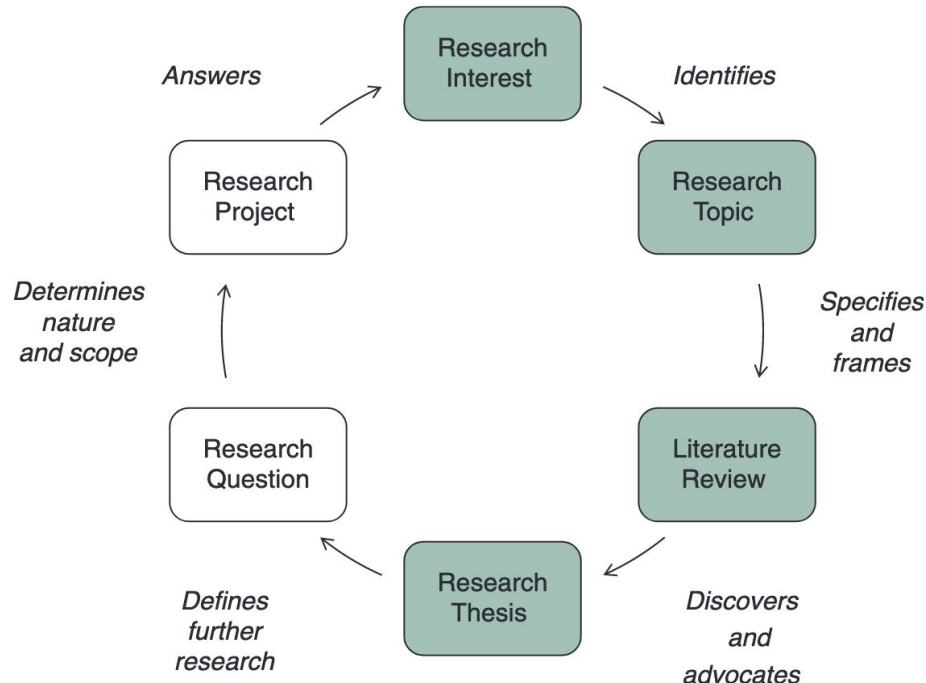
(Rozas et Klein, 2010, p. 389)

The Literature Review in Sociology

A plurality of approaches:

- *Narrative review* - “analyzes, and draws conclusions about what is known about a particular topic. Its purpose is to produce a position on the state of that knowledge” (Machi et McEvoy, 2022, p. 3)
- *Integrative review* - “delivers new perspectives on a particular topic by requiring critical analysis and creative synthesis” based on the various components of that topic (its history, different conceptualizations, methodological issues, interactions with other topics, etc.) (Rozas et Klein, 2010, p. 395)
- *Problem identification review* - “extends the work of the narrative review to identify and define an unanswered question requiring new primary research” (Machi et McEvoy, 2022, p. 1)

Figure I.2 The Research Problem Identification Literature Review



The Literature Review in Sociology

What, how and when to read?*

- Before conducting fieldwork:
 - Get some basic knowledge on your research topic;
 - Avoid repetition of existing studies (or inspire a *revisit* of existing fieldwork)
 - Risk of ***scholastic epistemo-centrism*** (Bourdieu 1997: 64–75)
- During/after fieldwork:
 - Helps reframe your research object, approach, adapt your interpretation (*abductive*)
 - Provide methodological guidance while confronting obstacles

The Literature Review in Sociology

What, how and when to read?

- **Thematic reading** - scientific literature on your research topic
 - Your research project MUST engage with that literature: discuss the main references of your field of research and position your project in it.
 - Tips: read first some general handbook on your topic (e.g. *Sociology of Precarity*) in order to have a quick idea of the main authors and methodological/analytical stakes.
- **Methodological reading**
 - Very different inquiries can be conducted on a same topic: you will have to “chose” (to design) your empirical method and analytic approach, and justify it in reference to methodological literature.
 - Tips: general handbooks might guides you into a general approach of your research object, though it can be uneasy to position yourself into a particular school of thoughts. I would advise you read articles exploring specific method problems you may encounter, read case-studies related to your topic, or even methodology sections in master/PhD thesis.

The Literature Review in Sociology

What, how and when to read? - Different reading strategies

- **Reading planning and document selection**
 - Plan your lit. review in different axes (thematics, analyticals) to explore.
 - Select the appropriate resources (documentary research) by reading only the title and abstract (or table of contents).
- **In-depth reading**
 - Only for identified “important” documents - that will be central in your review
 - Analyze the argument, take notes and discuss the text with your partners: you will have to engage with those important references in your research proposal.
- **“Quick” reading**
 - Useful to explore one aspect of the relevant literature. Take short notes and compare them with other documents in order to synthesize them effectively (write down pages for each idea or quotation!)
- **Recensions**
 - Read multiple recensions (2-4 pages) for each book that might interest you in order to grasp the main contribution of that reference, and the debates that might surround it.

The Literature Review in Sociology

To sum-up: What is expected from your lit. review

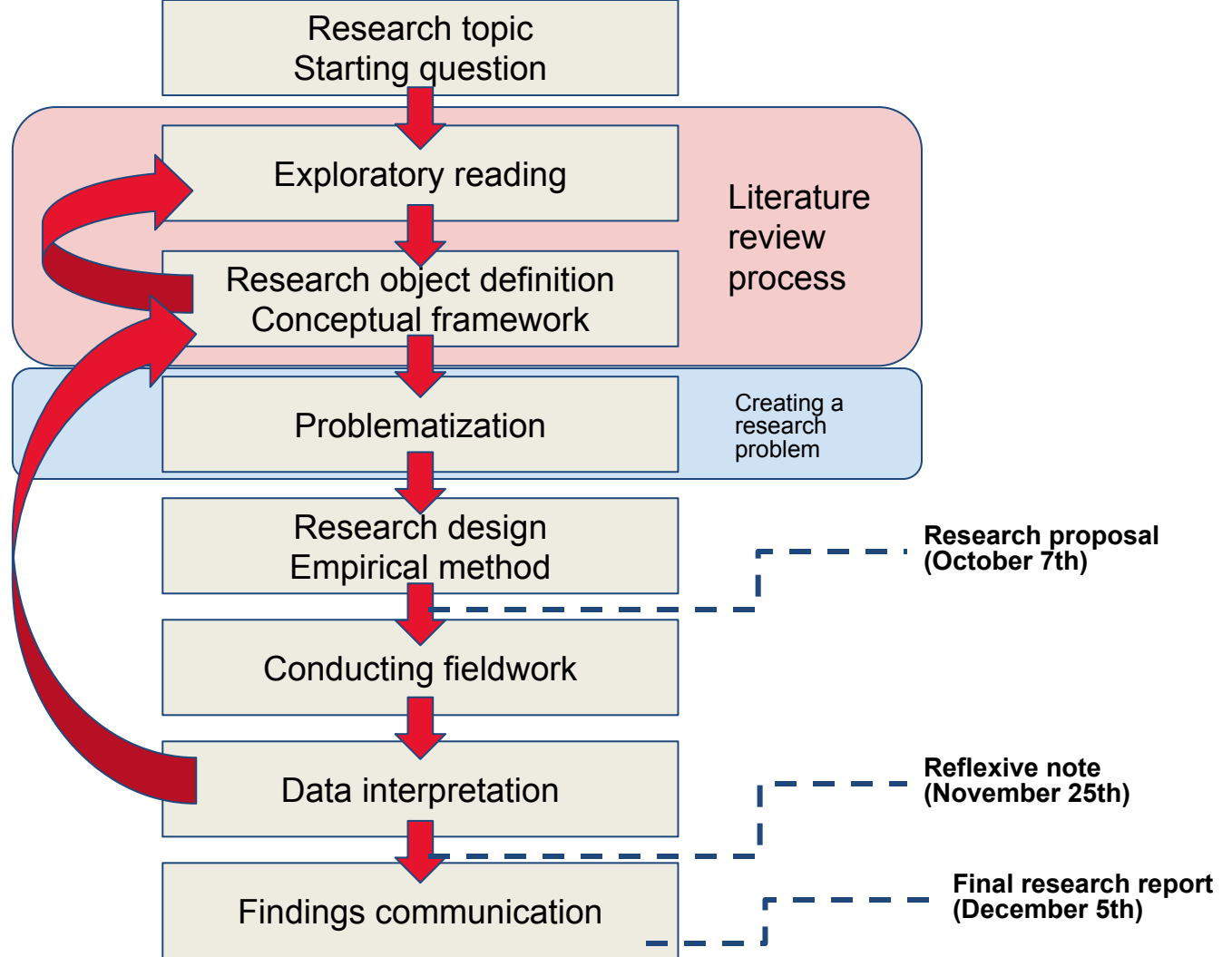
- A lit. review aim's at synthesizing the current state of research on a delimited topic in order to justify your research proposal:
 - It should not neglect any aspect of your research - your object definition, conceptual framework, empirical design & methodology.
 - You can only problematize your initial questions by confronting them with the relevant literature - before conducting your fieldwork (research proposal).
- A lit. review is not a catalog (no name-dropping):
 - Value (prioritize) argumentation and relevance over exhaustivity.
 - Your lit. review should be structured around a well-argued plan that takes a 'critical' stance on the literature, and logically leads to your problematization and research design.
 - Take extra care to avoid plagiarism: make sure you quote every idea or piece of information you read!

Any questions?

The Research Question and Problematization Process

The Heart of Your Research

Research Project Outline



The Research Question and Problematization Process

Discussion from the text: Gustafsson, Karl et Linus Hagström. « What is the point? Teaching graduate students how to construct political science research puzzles », *European Political Science*, 2018, vol.17 n° 4. p. 634-648.

- Recap the main arguments:
 - How a research project is traditionally justified (3 arguments)? Do they constitute a sufficient *rationale* for new research, why?
 - What is a “research puzzle”? What does it focus on?
 - Give an example of problematization (one is present in the text).

The Research Question and Problematization Process

Discussion from the text (Gustafsson et Hagström, 2018, p. 643):

- Filling a 'gap' or addressing a social/political problem might be a starting point, though they don't constitute a sufficient *rationale* for a new research.
- Problematization as "the practice of disrupting 'taken for granted' truths" (p.640), meaning you must engage with and challenge the existing literature and/or shared belief on your topic.
- Research puzzle:

Why X despite Y?

How did X become possible despite Y?

} With X a social phenomenon;
And Y a shared assumption based on existing literature

The Research Question and Problematization Process

Problematization in sociology: conditions for a valid scientific research question (from Lemieux, Cyril. « Problématiser » L'enquête sociologique. [s.l.] : Presses Universitaires de France. 2012, p. 27-51.)

- A sociological question is neither a scholastic question (speculative) nor a descriptive one, but rather a *critical* one that denaturalize a social phenomenon.
- To problematize in sociology is to formulate a puzzle (1) that *necessarily* calls for the construction of a sociological object (2) and an empirical inquiry (3).

The Research Question and Problematization Process

Problematization in sociology: conditions for a valid scientific research question (Lemieux 2012, p.30)

- Puzzling what seems normal - A recipe:
 - i. Take a shared belief or a recognized observation relating to the subject studied;
 - ii. Draw a serie of logical inferences or predictive statements from it;
 - iii. Reveal one or more empirical elements that contradict these statements;
 - iv. Ask how, if the shared beliefs are recognized to be true, these empirical elements can exist?

The Research Question and Problematization Process

Problematization in sociology: conditions for a valid scientific research question (Lemieux 2012, p. 38-42.)

- How to (re)construct a research object? *General principle:*
 - Your research object is the analytical model used to explain/understand a social phenomenon.
 - **To construct this explanatory/comprehensive model, you should *deconstruct* the natural (common) definition of your topic that contradicts an empirical observation (cf. puzzling), in order to *reconstruct* a definition able to integrate (explain/comprehend) that same empirical element.**

The Research Question and Problematization Process

Problematization in sociology: conditions for a valid scientific research question (Lemieux 2012, p. 38-42.)

- How to construct a research object? Precision on sociological explanation:
 - The **principle of double homogeneity in sociological explanation:**
 - **Symmetry principle** (D. Bloor): facts and counterfacts shall be explained by the same cause(s) - 1st condition of validity, called “horizontal homogeneity”.
 - **Clause of homogeneity of explanation** (E. Durkheim): “Social facts can only be explained by other social facts” - 2nd condition of validity, called “vertical homogeneity”
 - Meaning that your conceptual model must explain both “normal” and “anormal” empirical elements by investigating at least one common social explanation.

The Research Question and Problematization Process

Problematization in sociology: conditions for a valid scientific research question (Lemieux 2012, p. 38-42.)

- The necessary empiricism:
 - From the outset your sociological puzzle needs a contradictory fact or observation that enables you to problematize. This empirical element cannot logically be deducted from the existing academic or lay definition of your topic.
 - Tips: This early empirical data collection could be linked to your documentary research by looking for empirical datasets in the literature and reports, in the press, as well as elements of communication, personal experiences and previous observations, etc.

The Research Question and Problematization Process

To sum-up: What is expected from your problematization

- Use either empirical observation or a contradiction in the literature to build a research puzzle (Why X despite Y).
 - In both cases, you must engage critically with the existing literature on your topic in order to justify your contribution.
- In the formulation of your research problem and construction of your research object, make sure to preserve the sociological homogeneity of your conceptual framework in your attempt to answer your research question.
 - Explain all your observations under the same conceptual framework, AND remember that “social facts can only be explained by other social facts”.

Any questions?

Design Your Lit. Review Objectives (and Start Reading)

In-class activity

Design Your Lit. Review Objectives

Plan Your Reading Objectives:

- Brainstorm around your topic and start with simple questions: What do you need to know?
 - Decompose your starting research question into multiple sub-questions
 - Those sub-questions can be either theoretical (how does sociology consider that concept?) or empirical (what data have been produced on that matter?)
- For each sub-question, search for at least 3 academic sources (articles, chapters, reports) and try to synthesize the 3 of them in order to answer (even partially) your sub-question.
 - See my own method on paper (next slide)
- From your synthesis, find another question (theoretical or empirical) and repeat the process.
 - As you work in groups, brainstorm together the different axes you want to investigate and allocate them between each other. Each one of you can explore its theoretical or empirical axis and then share their findings in common to decide the next step (refine your research question - problematization - or think of your fieldwork!)

Reading Technique Suggestion

Your Notebook:

Sub-question:

First text

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-

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Second text

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-

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-

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Third text

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-

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Synthesis of the 3 texts:

New sub-question: Where do we go from there ?

Design Your Lit. Review Objectives

Tools for Documentary Research and Organization:

- Zotero (is mandatory) - organization, readings pdf and easy quotation
- Sciences Po Library's catalog (with AI suggestions)
- ProQuest (Sciences Po access, with AI help)
- Google Scholar, Academia (<https://www.academia.edu/>), Jstor, ResearchGate, Cairn (for pdf)

For the next session (September 23rd)

- **Start reading on your research topic and think of a research question**
- **Read the mandatory text from Olivier de Sardan (2015), “The Policy of Fieldwork”**